Speaking specifically on the ‘Hindu-Muslim’ refugee question and the internal party critique of his policies, Nehru drew a distinction between democratic principles and mob rule. The bottom-line was that he was not prepared ‘to accept for a single moment the theory trotted out by certain sections of Congressmen and others that democracy means that whatever people feel regarding any matter is to be accepted.’ The prime minister thundered: ‘If that is called democracy then I say, hell with such a democracy.’ And then he questioned, ‘What has happened to the minds of Congressmen? Do they want today to bow before what a mob says and compromise their principles? … I do not agree that Congressmen should do what the large majority of people ask to be done.’ Nehru’s emotional and hard-hitting speech won him a standing ovation. The same Congress leaders who earlier that month had voted Tandon in, passed Nehru’s ‘Resolution on Communalism’ with an overwhelming majority.[46] At least one newspaper noted that Sardar Patel had sat in silence through the entire proceedings as Nehru’s resolutions got passed. The Sardar’s ‘complete silence’ was ‘much commented upon’, but ‘perhaps there was nothing to it apart from his ill health’.[47]

Nehru’s speech won him the immediate battle, but tensions between the ‘secularists’ and the ‘Hindu nationalists’ continued to simmer. He left Nasik with a ‘disturbing suspicion’ that, while his partymen may have been shamed into siding with him, they may not really have bought his argument. He was ‘deeply troubled,’ he said, by a ‘feeling of different pools in the country and different pools and ideas within the Congress’.[48] The Congress’s Hindu traditionalists hit back within a year by forcing Communications Minister Rafi Ahmad Kidwai’s exit from Nehru’s cabinet on 2 August 1951. Kidwai, a key Nehru confidant, resigned as a Union government minister after months of feeling sidelined in internal party decision-making by Tandon and his group, whom he accused of working in an ‘undemocratic manner’ against the principles of the Congress. In a strong statement against the Congress President, Kidwai publicly asked, ‘Is there a parallel in the world where the executive head i.e. the President of an organisation is the very antithesis of everything that the organisation stands for? What is there in common between Shri Purshottamdas Tandon and the policies of the Congress—